

Young Adult Starter Guide

English

Person before diagnosis.
Dignity before compliance.
Relationship before activity.
Engagement before completion.

You do not need to be a dementia expert

Young Adult Starter Guide

1. Understand

Dementia may affect word-finding, memory, attention, pace, and the ability to follow several ideas. Humor, emotion, preferences, skills, identity, and the wish to connect may remain. Meet the person, not a diagnosis.

2. Prepare

Prepare lightly: learn the preferred name and interests; choose two topics and one optional activity; check sound, light, and privacy.

3. Connect

Begin with a friendly observation. Ask one question at a time, wait, and listen for what brings energy. Share something about yourself too.

4. Adapt

When memory is difficult, give information freely. Do not quiz, argue, rush, or correct every detail. Respond to meaning and feeling.

5. Use activities

Activities are invitations into conversation. Stop, simplify, or change them whenever needed.

6. End well

End with a gentle time cue, name one enjoyable moment, and build a bridge to next time. Keep contact within program boundaries and follow safeguarding procedures.

What may change - and what may remain

A person may need more time to understand or respond, lose a word, repeat a thought, or find several choices overwhelming. These changes vary from person to person and from day to day.

A familiar voice, humor, emotion, rhythm, long-held skills, preferences, and the wish to belong may remain powerful. Never assume that difficulty speaking means there is nothing to communicate.

Your role is a conversation partner

You are not a clinician, examiner, or substitute caregiver. Your job is to create the conditions for a comfortable exchange: attention, patience, curiosity, and room for the older person to contribute.

Reciprocity matters. Ask with genuine interest, share appropriately about your own life, and let the relationship change your perspective too.

Build a simple session plan

Write down an easy opening, two possible topics, one optional activity, a familiar redirection subject, and a gentle ending cue. Use only what helps.

Protect privacy. Use authorized images and approved contact methods. Never record or share a session without permission.

Listen with your whole attention

Notice words, gesture, gaze, expression, rhythm, and tone. A smile, point, hum, correction, question, or longer answer may show a spark. Stay with it.

Silence does not need to be repaired immediately. Count slowly, keep a relaxed expression, and give the person a chance to continue.

When a conversation becomes difficult

Reduce the demand: one idea, one image, or two clear choices. Give missing information freely. Move from exact recall to preference, feeling, sound, color, place, or sensory detail.

If frustration grows, acknowledge it and change direction. If the person is tired or wants to stop, end without disappointment.

Boundaries and safeguarding

Keep communication within approved times, platforms, and program roles. Do not give medical, legal, or financial advice. Do not exchange private contact information unless the program permits it.

If someone shares a concern, listen calmly, do not investigate or promise secrecy, preserve their words accurately, and follow the safeguarding process. Contact emergency services for immediate danger.

Evidence behind this guide

Full references

Evidence note: Informed by the seven systematic reviews and evidence syntheses listed at sageandseed.org/full-references.html. Evidence for communication skills and meaningful interaction is more consistent than evidence for broader clinical outcomes.

This practical resource supports communication and engagement. It is not medical advice, therapy, clinical training, or certification. Follow local safeguarding and supervisory procedures.